

****Words that Kill via Social Media****

Intervention by Guido Scorza, member of the Guarantor for the protection of personal data
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A 23-year-old boy – the same age as Vincent – who chooses to take his own life live, in front of his powered-on smartphone, after accusations on the web. It is worth writing about, talking about, discussing, and above all, questioning what can – and indeed must – be done so that no other young lives are abruptly cut short in the same way.

Vincent, in the registry, Inquisitor ghost on TikTok, took his life live on the popular social platform – presumably – because, of course, it is up to the judiciary to ascertain beyond a reasonable doubt what happened – because he could not withstand the accusations of being a pedophile that had literally overwhelmed him online, false accusations deliberately spread – or at least this is the hypothesis under investigation – to discredit him and prevent him from taking off as a successful content producer, depriving others of contacts, interactions, popularity, and perhaps even money and success.

If we hadn't, unfortunately, already seen this happen, it would all seem absurd. A 23-year-old boy – the same age as Vincent – who chooses to take his own life live, in front of his powered-on smartphone, on an ordinary evening, at home, because he was battered by the violence of words via social media, violence inspired – if that is how things stand – by fear that he would take away a handful of likes and interactions from someone on social media.

And yet it happened, and among the many things that can happen, there is one that must not happen: that this story slips past us like an inevitable accident, a dramatic and undesirable side effect of the dynamics of the digital society in which we live.

Therefore, it is worth writing about, talking about, discussing, and above all, questioning what can – and indeed must – be done so that no other young lives are abruptly cut short in the same way. And, in this perspective, one reflection seems more important than many others: words can hurt as much, if not more, than physical violence, but social media users, starting with the youngest, do not know this, do not understand it, do not realize it. "I never wanted this to happen. What happened to him is completely wrong," wrote, precisely on social media, one of the main suspects of having spread the infamous accusation that Vincent was a pedophile.

And, probably, he is telling the truth. There is a rush to share every kind of content on social media, digital attacks are launched against defenseless and innocent victims, and one literally transforms into a perpetrator without realizing it. This happens today, before our eyes, behind the sparkling lights of platforms that churn out millions of dollars every hour, also thanks to violent, extremely violent, and inhumane content. This occurs for a multitude of reasons, attributable to a variety of different subjects, and it would be neither fair nor intellectually honest to point the finger only at some while absolving others. We are, first and foremost, facing an educational failure: we have found ourselves and have put extraordinarily powerful tools in the hands of children of all ages without having invested enough – or perhaps, at least for years, without having invested anything – in educating them for their conscious and safe use, underestimating risks that, unfortunately, today are becoming increasingly frequent with dark and dramatic hues.

Here we have all made mistakes, each in their role as an adult, parent, educator, informant, public decision-maker. But alongside this educational failure, there is another issue: are we sure that social platforms are designed, developed, and managed in such a way as to prioritize the well-being of users – starting with that of the youngest, of course – over the legitimate pursuit of profit?

Unfortunately, I believe it is difficult to say with certainty. It is hard to deny that certain platforms – because generalizing is always risky – make sharing every kind of content easier, more immediate, and more impulsive than would be appropriate. It is difficult to deny that with the intent of maximizing the circulation of content, which, with a certain approximation, means increasing their profits, they compress, perhaps beyond reason, the space for reflection, consideration, and caution that would be advisable before sharing content among millions or billions of users, before labeling a young boy as a

pedophile who is not.

It is difficult to deny that the algorithms of many social platforms push certain types of content further, those with stronger tones – not necessarily violent, for heaven's sake – more divisive, more capable of generating attention and interactions, and are a bit lazy, instead, in realizing that an unsustainable storm of infamy is descending upon the profile of a young boy who cannot withstand its impact. And here, perhaps, we need to take action before it is too late. The point is not that social managers legitimately rake in billion-dollar profits, but the point is that it seems truly essential that in doing so, they take on the responsibility of prioritizing the well-being and safety of users, starting with the youngest, investing – genuinely and not just with techwashing actions and campaigns – in designing and planning their platforms differently from how they have done so far.

The youngest, to begin with, should simply be kept away from using tools that are evidently too powerful for them. And then, it should fall to – not exclusively but primarily...

– those who make billion-dollar profits from their use, educate users, starting with the youngest, on a conscious and responsible use of certain tools, services, and platforms. And it is a shame if doing so means sacrificing profits, making the sharing of certain content slower because it is more considered, inviting users to think for two more minutes before sharing content rather than pushing them to do so by merely tapping the screen of a smartphone.

But, of course, once we manage to impose on the social media giants the consideration of the well-being of humanity and that of children as an insurmountable and non-negotiable constraint on the altar of their legitimate profits, there is no doubt that those who have literally changed the way billions of people live could and would know how to find technological solutions to ensure that the digital environment is safer than it is today, at least and especially for the youngest.